



Called Last, Known First: Timing a Junior Sports Club's Formal Pathway-Conversation Call Against the First Mention of a Cut in the Team Group Chat

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Abstract. Junior sports clubs that adopt a formal post-tryout “pathway conversation” typically present it as the moment a family learns whether their child made the team, delivered by a coach following a structured, empathetic script. We test whether the call is, in practice, first. Across 246 tryout cycles at 21 clubs spanning three codes over one season, we timestamp each formal call against the first message in the team group chat that names the specific player’s inclusion or exclusion, matching club call logs against message timestamps volunteered by consenting families. The chat carries the news before the call in 189 of 246 cycles (76.8%), with a median lead time of roughly twenty-one hours. Coaches who completed a structured feedback-script micro-course show no reduction in this lead time relative to untrained coaches (1,260 vs. 1,250 minutes, n.s.). The chat’s early mentions are correct in 90.5% of cases, and where wrong, more often optimistic than not. We discuss the pathway conversation less as news delivery than as a scheduled confirmation of news the chat has already delivered, and consider what a communication protocol becomes once its central act has already happened before it starts.

Introduction

A junior sports club’s tryout period ends the same way it always has: a list is drawn up, and some names are on it and some are not. What has changed is what happens next. Where an earlier generation of clubs left the outcome to travel however it travelled — a phone call if the coach got around to it, a shrug at the next training session if not — a growing number now formalise the moment. A rostered coach places a scheduled call to every family whose child did not make the team, following a script modelled loosely on structured bad-news protocols developed for clinical and workplace settings [1], and the club logs that the call was made.

The formalisation answers a real complaint: earlier accounts of deselection in youth sport describe outcomes delivered badly or not at all, and identify a communication vacuum as part of what makes the moment harder than it needs to

be [2], [3], [4]. Guidance now exists for running the process well [5], [6], and clubs that adopt a formal call are, on paper, closing that gap.

What the formal call cannot control is the parallel channel it sits beside. Youth sport already runs substantially on a team group chat, the default coordination tool for training changes, car-pools, and canteen rosters alike [7], [8], and organisational communication research has long observed that informal channels move faster than formal ones precisely because they are not waiting for anyone’s turn to make a call [9], [10], [11]. A cut list, unlike a quarterly earnings figure, is visible in real time to anyone standing at the fence during the final trial session.

This paper asks a narrow, timing-only question: when a club runs both a formal pathway conversation and an ordinary team group chat, which one actually delivers the news first, and does training the coach in the formal script change

the answer. We make no claim about which channel families prefer, only about which one arrives.

Related work

Organisational rumour research treats the informal channel not as a failure of the formal one but as a structurally faster alternative: DiFonzo and Bordia find corporate rumour to be substantially accurate even though it forms and spreads outside any sanctioned process [9], and Bordia and colleagues show that uncertainty during organisational change is what activates the informal network in the first place, with the formal channel typically catching up once a decision is already common knowledge [10], [11]. A tryout cut list is exactly this kind of decision: made once, known to several observers immediately, and communicated formally on a delay set by rostering rather than by information availability.

The youth sport literature supplies the other half of the picture: deselection is a high-stakes moment for the athletes and families on the receiving end [2], [3], [4], communication guidance for it is an active area of applied research [5], [6], and the team group chat is already the dominant coordination surface between clubs and families [7], [8], one whose norms and reliability under pressure are themselves under study [12], [13], [14]. Prior work at this institution has found that a street garage-sale group chat's mere response, independent of its content, raises sellers' price confidence [15]; the present study asks whether a chat's informational content, not merely its presence, can pre-empt a scheduled institutional channel altogether. It sits alongside the University's continuing interest in the gap between a channel's official standing and what the channel actually delivers [16].

Method

Sample. Twenty-one clubs across three codes (football, netball, basketball) within a single regional junior-sport association agreed to participate over one season, each having already introduced a formal pathway-conversation call for non-selected players prior to the study. Nine clubs' coaching staff had completed a widely used structured feedback-script micro-course before the season; twelve had not. Every tryout cycle that ended in at least one non-selection, and for which both a call timestamp and con-

senting-family chat data were available, entered the sample: 246 cycles in total (Football 84, Netball 81, Basketball 81).

Timestamps. Each club's team-management platform logs the exact time a scheduled pathway-conversation call is placed; we took this as t_{call} . Families who consented (one per non-selected player) provided a de-identified export of their team group chat's message timestamps; a message was coded as the **first mention** if it named, directly or by clear reference, the specific player's inclusion or exclusion status, independently of whether the mention was accurate. The earliest such message defines t_{chat} . Both timestamps are recorded relative to t_0 , the moment the final trial session's squad split is read out or posted to the whiteboard — observable to any parent or player still on the sideline, but not itself a communication about any individual player.

Lead time. For each cycle, lead time is

$$L = t_{\text{call}} - t_{\text{chat}}$$

A positive L indicates the chat carried the news first; the club's own scheduling policy, not this study, determines when t_{call} falls.

Accuracy. Each first mention was compared against the club's own final team sheet and coded *correct*, *overstated* (claimed selection that did not occur), or *understated* (claimed a cut that did not occur), by two coders blind to the eventual chat-versus-call comparison (Cohen's $\kappa = 0.88$).

Ablation. To test whether the feedback-script training changes the timing race rather than only the call's content, we compare L between cycles delivered by a script-trained coach and cycles delivered by an untrained coach, holding the chat side of the comparison constant.

Results

Code	Clubs	Cycles	Trained-coach cycles
Football	7	84	45
Netball	7	81	33
Basketball	7	81	30
Total	21	246	108

Table 1 summarises the sample across the three codes; nine of the twenty-one clubs' coaching

staff had completed the feedback-script micro-course, accounting for 108 of the 246 cycles.

The team chat named a specific player's outcome before the formal call was placed in 189 of 246 cycles (76.8%), and after it in the remaining 57 (23.2%; the call was never earlier by more than a few minutes in this residual group, consistent with a chat message crossed in transit rather than a genuinely call-first cycle).

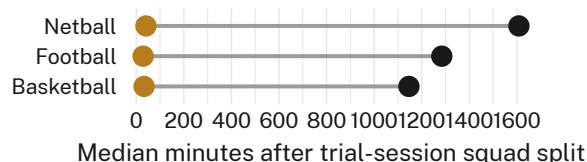


Figure 1: The team chat's first mention of a cut lands within the hour across all three codes (29–41 minutes after the squad split); the formal pathway-conversation call lands the following evening (19–27 hours later).

Lead time did not depend on whether the delivering coach had completed feedback-script training.



Figure 2: Lead time (call minus chat, minutes) by coach training status. Script-trained coaches: median 1,260 minutes; untrained coaches: median 1,250 minutes (Mann-Whitney U , $p = 0.81$).

The script changes how the call is delivered once it happens; it does not move when it happens. Lead time held even after restricting to the 108 trained-coach cycles alone (median 1,260 minutes) and to first-child families only (median 1,255 minutes across 172 cycles), suggesting the finding is not an artefact of experienced multi-child families gaming the comparison.

Where the chat's early mention was checked against the eventual team sheet, it was correct in 171 of 189 cases (90.5%). Incorrect mentions

ran roughly twice as often toward overstating a player's chances as toward understating them (13 overstated versus 5 understated, aggregated across codes), a pattern consistent across all three.

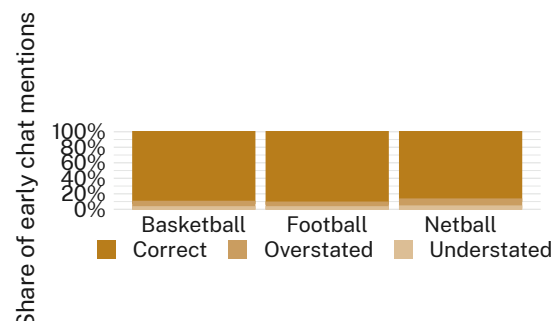


Figure 3: Composition of the team chat's early mentions by code: correct, overstated, or understated relative to the eventual team sheet. Overstated mentions outnumber understated ones in every code studied.

Discussion

The formal pathway conversation is not, on this evidence, how families learn whether their child made the team. It is closer to a scheduled confirmation of news the team chat delivered the previous afternoon, arriving with enough procedural weight — a booked call, a trained voice, a script drawn from clinical bad-news protocols [1] — to read as the primary channel even when it demonstrably is not. This is consistent with a broader pattern in organisational communication, where a sanctioned channel's authority over an outcome and its speed in reporting that outcome are only loosely coupled [9], [11]. Training the coach in the script improves what happens during the nineteen-to-twenty-seven-hour wait, evidently, without touching the wait itself, because the wait is set by rostering capacity rather than by anything the training addresses. A club that wants the formal conversation to be the news, rather than a debrief on news already circulating, would need to compress t_{call} toward t_0 , not refine what is said once the call finally arrives.

Limitations

Our sample draws on one regional association's clubs across three codes and one season; associations with slower or faster rostering cycles for pathway-conversation calls may show a narrower gap, though the chat's own timing — set by trial-session visibility rather than club admin-

istration — should generalise more readily than the call's does. Family consent to donate chat timestamps was required for inclusion, which may under-represent families who left the chat, or the club, before the call was due; if anything this suggests our lead-time estimate is conservative, since a family that has already left the chat by the time of the call has, by definition, already known for a while. The coder-agreement figure for mention accuracy, while high, rests on message text alone, without access to the tone in which it was delivered — a stricter test than the one most claims of chat accuracy in the literature are held to, which if anything makes 90.5% a floor rather than a ceiling.

Conclusion

Across three codes and one season, the team group chat told families whether their child made the tryout roughly a day before the club's own scheduled call did, and training the calling coach in a structured feedback script left that gap untouched. A pathway conversation billed as delivering news functions, for three families in four, as a formally minuted response to news already known. Future work might test whether compressing the call's own schedule — rather than further refining its script — is the lever that actually changes what the conversation is for, and whether families experience a same-day call differently even when its content is unchanged from what the chat already told them.

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